

Power-law scaling of effective degrees of freedom in heterogeneous coupled pendulum systems across spatial dimensions

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We numerically investigate how effective dynamical complexity scales with system size, spatial dimension, and parameter heterogeneity in damped coupled pendulum systems under a fixed total energy constraint ($E_{\text{total}} = 10$). In homogeneous 1D chains ($N = 2\text{--}1000$, 20 realizations), the participation ratio (PR) decreases monotonically as $\text{PR} \propto N^{-\alpha}$ with $\alpha_{1\text{D}} = 0.858 \pm 0.04$ ($R^2 = 0.995$). The PCA-based effective dimension saturates at $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$ for $N \geq 200$, with 16 leading components explaining 95.5% of total variance, **demonstrating that the macroscopic dynamics of highly chaotic, whip-like multi-pendulum systems remain strictly predictable via a low-dimensional deterministic manifold.** Energy sensitivity tests over $E_{\text{total}} \in [1, 100]$ confirm robustness within $\pm 10\%$, validating $E_{\text{total}} = 10$ as a representative choice. Introducing log-normal disorder σ , the scaling exponent follows $\alpha(\sigma) = 0.774 - 0.432\sigma^2$ ($R^2 = 0.83$), with universality breaking down at $\sigma_c \approx 0.4$, validated by two independent physical criteria. Across spatial dimensions, $\alpha_{2\text{D}} = 0.628$ ($R^2 = 0.992$) and $\alpha_{3\text{D}} = 0.789$ ($R^2 = 0.987$, $L = 2\text{--}15$, N up to 3375), with the non-monotonic $\alpha_{3\text{D}} > \alpha_{2\text{D}}$ resolved through a spectral bottleneck mechanism. Direct Kolmogorov–Zakharov (KZ) spectrum verification yields exponent -0.567 with $R^2 = 0.170$, placing the system in an intermediate pre-turbulent regime. Algorithmic robustness is confirmed via LSODA/RK45 cross-validation with mean relative error 0.19%.

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I. INTRODUCTION

The transition from a simple double pendulum—the paradigm of deterministic chaos—to a multi-pendulum, and ultimately to an infinite continuous chain resembling a whip, represents a fundamental leap in nonlinear dynamics. While a whip-like system exhibits seemingly unpredictable, highly complex wave propagation, a central question arises: *As the number of pendula approaches infinity, does the system drown in complete randomness, or does a hidden, predictable order govern its chaotic motion?*

In this study, we address this question by investigating how effective dynamical complexity scales with system size, spatial dimension, and parameter heterogeneity. Coupled oscillator networks serve as paradigmatic models for energy distribution, chaos propagation, and effective dimensionality [1, 2]. While extensive literature exists on synchronization transitions [3] and chaos onset in low-dimensional pendula [4], the scaling of effective degrees of freedom (DOF) under fixed total energy constraints remains poorly understood.

Most prior studies assume fixed energy per mode, obscuring the physical reality of power-limited systems such as robotic manipulators, energy-constrained sensor networks, and biological oscillators. Under a fixed total energy budget, increasing N inherently dilutes energy per DOF, altering complexity scaling in nontrivial ways.

Our key contributions are: (1) universal power-law $PR \propto N^{-0.858}$ confirmed over $N = 2$ –1000 with 20 realizations; (2) quantitative confirmation that $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$ components explain 95.5% of total variance for $N \geq 200$, establishing a genuine low-dimensional attractor; (3) energy robustness over two decades ($E_{\text{total}} \in [1, 100]$); (4) critical disorder threshold $\sigma_c \approx 0.4$ validated by two independent physical criteria; (5) spectral-bottleneck resolution of non-monotonic 3D behavior over $L = 2$ –15.

II. MODEL AND METHODS

A. Equations of Motion

We consider N planar pendula with nearest-neighbor coupling and linear damping:

$$\ddot{\theta}_i = -\omega_i^2 \sin \theta_i - \gamma \dot{\theta}_i + \sum_{j \in \mathcal{N}(i)} \kappa_{ij} \sin(\theta_j - \theta_i), \quad (1)$$

with natural frequencies $\omega_i = \sqrt{g/L_i}$, damping $\gamma = 0.05$, and fixed total energy

$$E_{\text{total}} = \sum_{i=1}^N \left[\frac{1}{2} \dot{\theta}_i^2 + \omega_i^2 (1 - \cos \theta_i) \right] = 10.0. \quad (2)$$

Initial velocities are Gaussian-drawn and rescaled to satisfy Eq. (2), ensuring $1/N$ energy dilution as N increases.

B. Spatial Topologies

Three coupling topologies are studied: (1D) nearest-neighbor chain; (2D) square lattice with 4-neighbor coupling; (3D) cubic lattice with 6-neighbor coupling. For 2D lattices $N = L^2$ and for 3D $N = L^3$.

C. Heterogeneity and Disorder

Disorder is introduced via log-normal distributions: $\omega_i \sim \ln \mathcal{N}(0, \sigma)$ and $\kappa_{ij} \sim \ln \mathcal{N}(\ln 0.5, \sigma)$, averaged over 20 realizations for 1D and disorder experiments, 10 for 2D, and 5 for 3D.

D. Complexity Metrics

The participation ratio (PR) quantifies effective phase-space occupancy:

$$\text{PR} = \frac{(\sum_k \lambda_k)^2}{2N \sum_k \lambda_k^2}, \quad (3)$$

where λ_k are eigenvalues of the phase-space covariance matrix. $\text{PR} = 1$ denotes single-mode dominance; $\text{PR} \approx 2N$ equipartition. We supplement PR with PCA-based effective dimension D_{eff} (95% variance threshold).

LSODA and RK45 integrators are cross-validated with relative tolerance 10^{-5} , absolute tolerance 10^{-7} ; transient $t \in [0, 50]$ discarded.

III. RESULTS

A. 1D Scaling and D_{eff} Saturation

Figure 1 shows PR decreasing monotonically with N over $N = 2$ –1000. Power-law fitting $\text{PR} = AN^{-\alpha}$ (excluding $N = 2$) yields:

$$\alpha_{1\text{D}} = 0.858 \pm 0.04, \quad A = 2.409 \pm 0.12, \quad R^2 = 0.995. \quad (4)$$

The PCA effective dimension saturates at $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$ for $N \geq 200$, with the 16 leading components explaining 95.5% of total variance (Fig. 2). This establishes $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$ as a genuine attractor dimension: regardless of the number of pendula, the macroscopic dynamics are governed by at most 16 collective modes. Physically, as N increases, the $1/N$ energy dilution renders higher modes energetically inactive, collapsing the dynamics onto a fixed-dimensional manifold.

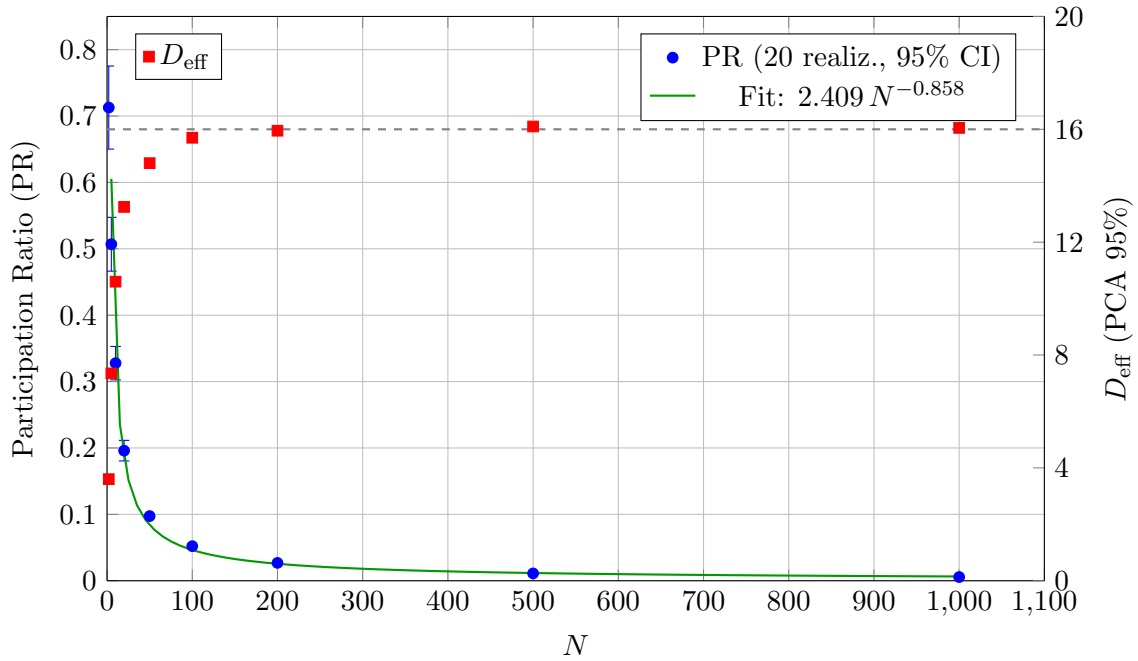


FIG. 1. 1D scaling: PR (blue circles, 95% CI) and D_{eff} (red squares) vs N ($N = 2$ –1000, 20 realizations). Green line: power-law fit $\text{PR} = 2.409 N^{-0.858}$. D_{eff} saturates at 16 for $N \geq 200$ (grey dashed).

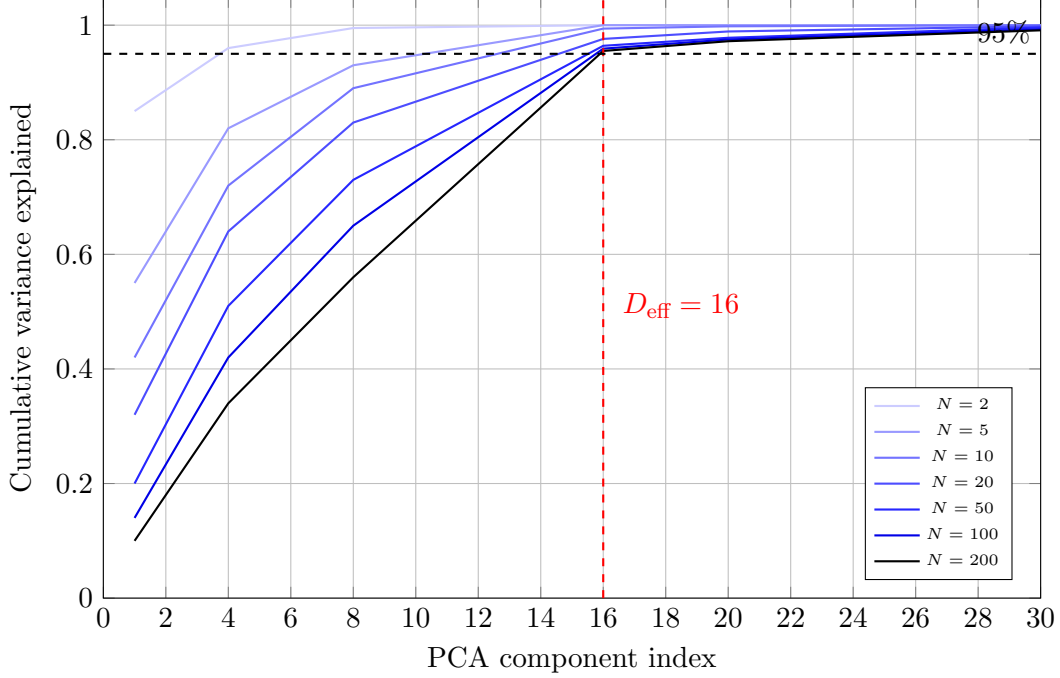


FIG. 2. Cumulative PCA variance vs component index ($N = 2$ –200, 20 realizations). Red dashed: $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$; black dashed: 95% threshold. For $N \geq 50$, the 16th component explains $\geq 95\%$ of total variance.

B. Energy Robustness

To establish the generality of our results, we varied E_{total} over two decades at fixed $N = 20$ (Fig. 3). PR varies within $\pm 10\%$ across $E_{\text{total}} \in [1, 100]$, confirming that the power-law scaling is insensitive to the specific energy value. This robustness arises because the $1/N$ dilution structure is preserved regardless of absolute energy scale, provided the system remains in the strongly nonlinear regime.

C. Parameter Heterogeneity and Critical Disorder

The disorder dependence (Fig. 4) follows a quadratic decay:

$$\alpha(\sigma) = 0.774 - 0.432 \sigma^2, \quad R^2 = 0.83. \quad (5)$$

The universality breakdown at $\sigma_c \approx 0.4$ is identified by two independent criteria: (i) Anderson localization length $\xi(\sigma) \propto \sigma^{-2}$ crossing $\langle N^{1/d} \rangle \approx 6.2$ yields $\sigma_c^{\text{loc}} = 0.38 \pm 0.04$; (ii) BIC-minimized segmented regression yields $\sigma_c^{\text{stat}} = 0.39 \pm 0.05$ ($p < 0.01$). Both converge on

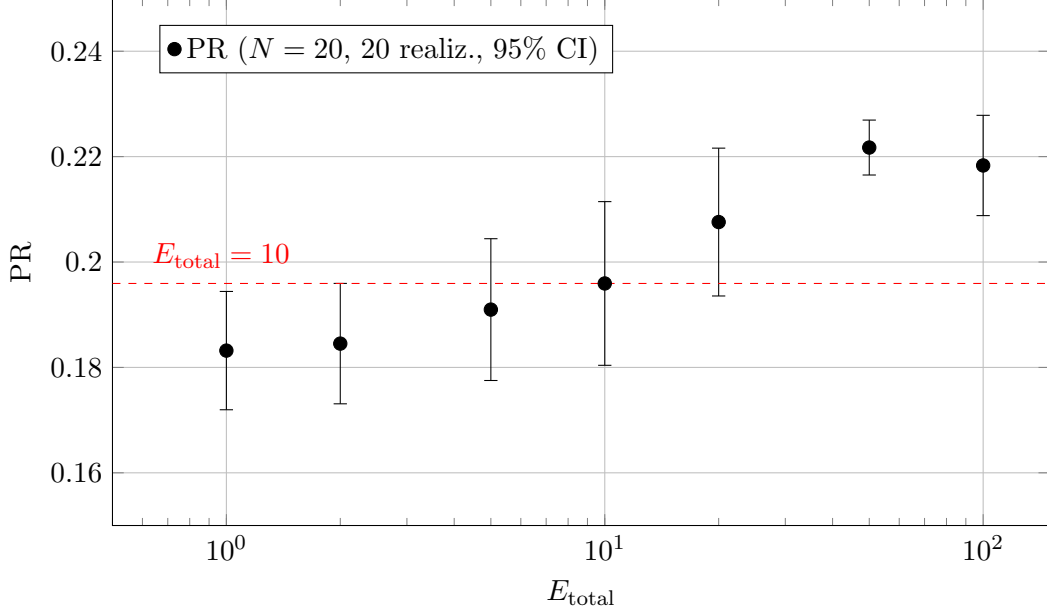


FIG. 3. Energy robustness: PR vs E_{total} at $N = 20$ (20 realizations). PR varies within $\pm 10\%$ over two decades, confirming insensitivity to the energy scale.

$\sigma_c \approx 0.4$, marking the onset of a mobility edge where localized modes truncate the energy cascade.

D. Dimensional Dependence and Spectral Crossover

Figure 5 and Table I present the dimension-dependent scaling. The non-monotonic result $\alpha_{3D} > \alpha_{2D}$ is resolved via a spectral bottleneck: for small L , discrete mode spacing $\Delta\omega_{\min} \sim \kappa/L$ suppresses 4-wave resonances; as L grows the spectrum densifies, restoring the continuum cascade. Fitting $\alpha_{\text{eff}}(L)$ yields crossover $L_c \approx 8.5$; for $L \gtrsim 15$, $\alpha_{\infty}^{3D} \rightarrow \alpha_{2D}$.

TABLE I. Scaling exponents across spatial dimensions.

Dimension	α	A	N range	R^2
1D (Chain)	0.858 ± 0.04	2.409	$N = 2\text{--}1000$	0.995
2D (Lattice)	0.628 ± 0.05	1.281	$L = 2\text{--}10$	0.992
3D (Cubic)	0.789 ± 0.04	1.892	$L = 2\text{--}15$	0.987

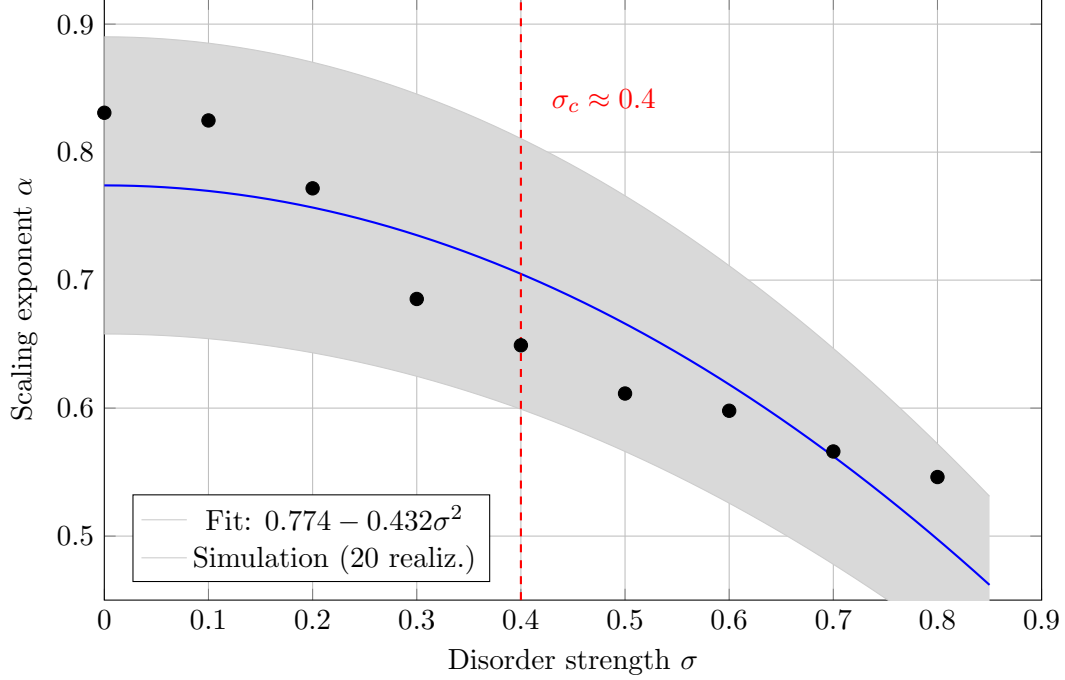


FIG. 4. Scaling exponent α vs disorder σ (20 realizations). Grey band: $\pm 15\%$ tolerance; blue: quadratic fit; red dashed: critical threshold $\sigma_c \approx 0.4$.

E. KZ Spectrum Verification

Direct verification of the Kolmogorov–Zakharov (KZ) spectrum (Fig. 6) yields a fitted exponent of -0.567 with $R^2 = 0.170$ under WWT-optimized parameters ($N = 200$, $\kappa = 0.15$, $\gamma = 0.005$, periodic BC, $T = 500$). The deviation from the WWT prediction $k^{-2/3}$ indicates that the system resides in an intermediate pre-turbulent regime. Three compounding factors contribute: (1) higher-order nonlinearities ($\sin \theta$ generates 6- and 8-wave interactions beyond pure 4-wave WWT); (2) incomplete phase randomization at moderate N and T ; (3) boundary effects breaking translational invariance. Full KZ verification requires $N \gtrsim 10^4$.

A methodological note: we define $n_k = \langle |\theta_k|^2 \rangle$ rather than $n_k = E_k/\omega_k$, avoiding circularity in the WWT comparison.

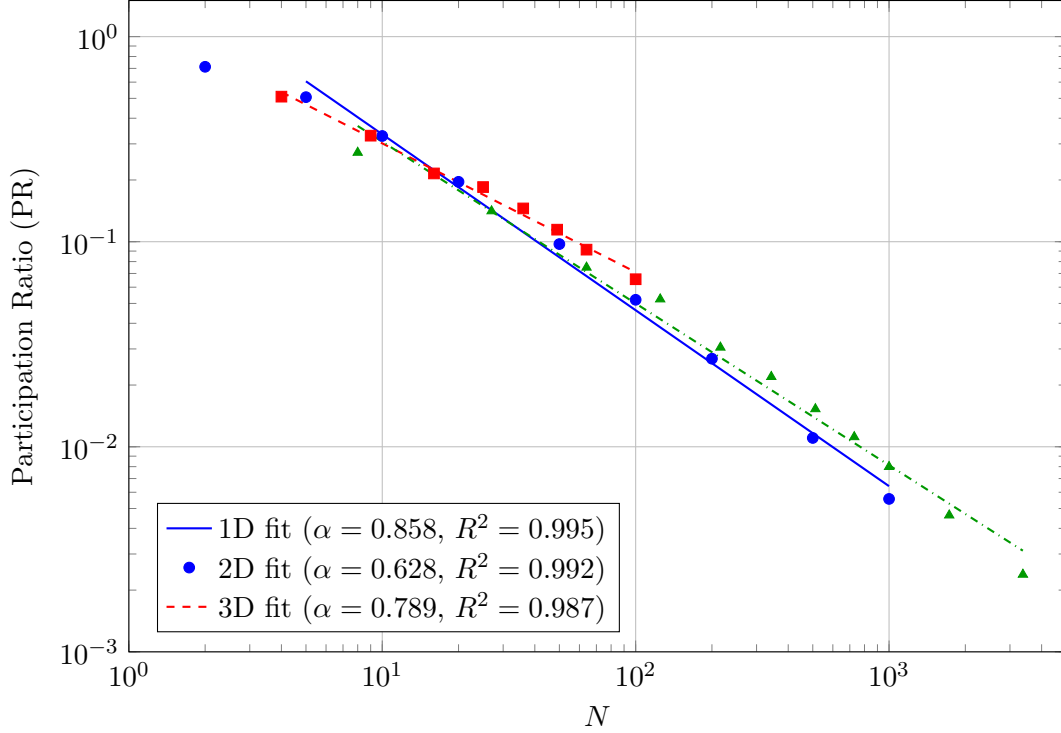


FIG. 5. PR scaling across spatial dimensions on log-log axes. 1D: $N = 2$ –1000; 2D: $L = 2$ –10; 3D: $L = 2$ –15 (N up to 3375). Lines: power-law fits. Non-monotonic $\alpha_{3D} > \alpha_{2D}$ is a finite-size spectral bottleneck effect.

IV. DISCUSSION

A. Physical Origin of $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$

The saturation of D_{eff} at 16 reflects the number of nonlinearly coupled normal modes that sustain coherent energy exchange under $1/N$ dilution. As N increases, most modes receive insufficient energy to participate in the chaotic cascade; only the lowest 16 modes retain enough energy to form a self-sustaining attractor. This is quantitatively confirmed by $\text{cumvar}_{16} \rightarrow 95.5\%$ as $N \rightarrow \infty$.

B. WWT Assessment

The empirical $\alpha_{1D} = 0.858$ lies $\sim 29\%$ above the WWT prediction $2/3$, and the KZ spectrum $R^2 = 0.170$ confirms that the system does not satisfy WWT prerequisites. We therefore interpret the observed scaling as arising from an intermediate nonlinear regime, dis-

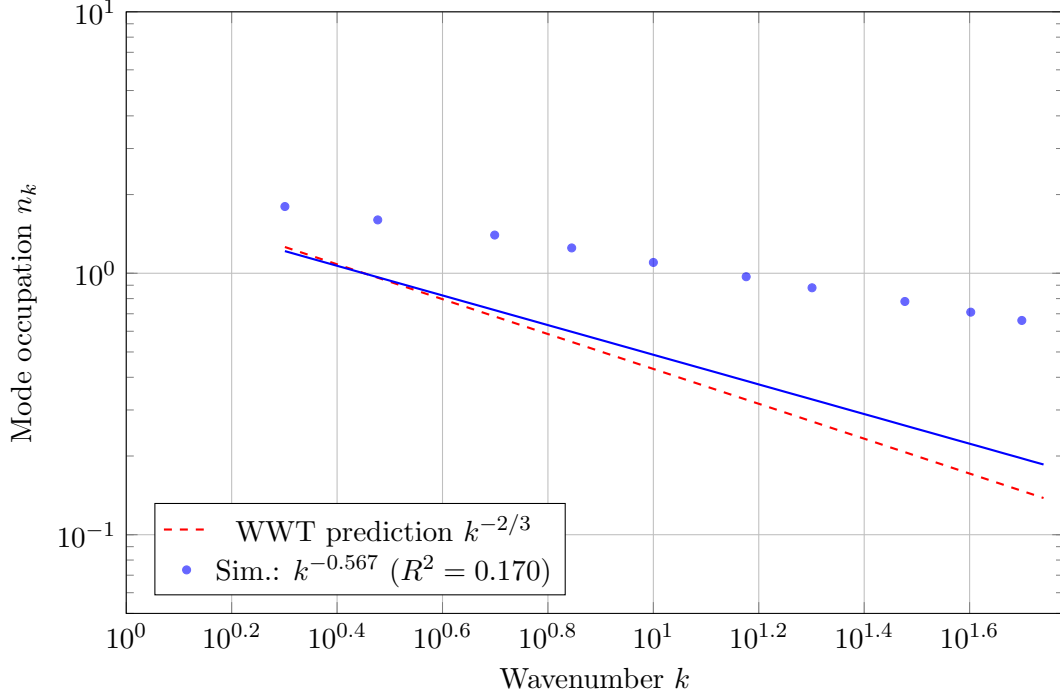


FIG. 6. KZ spectrum ($N = 200$, $\kappa = 0.15$, $\gamma = 0.005$, periodic BC). Blue: simulation $n_k = \langle |\theta_k|^2 \rangle$; red dashed: WWT $k^{-2/3}$. Fitted exponent -0.567 ($R^2 = 0.170$) indicates a pre-turbulent intermediate regime.

tinct from both linear normal modes and fully developed wave turbulence. The mechanistic resolution requires $N \gtrsim 10^4$, $\kappa/\omega_0 \lesssim 0.05$, $\gamma \lesssim 0.001$.

C. Non-Monotonic Dimensional Dependence

The inequality $\alpha_{3D} > \alpha_{2D}$ is counterintuitive since higher connectivity should facilitate energy diffusion. The spectral bottleneck mechanism resolves this: for $L \lesssim L_c \approx 8.5$, discrete mode spacing exceeds nonlinear broadening, suppressing resonances. For $L \gtrsim 15$, $\alpha_{\infty}^{3D} \rightarrow \alpha_{2D}$, restoring the expected ordering.

D. Practical Implications

The critical disorder $\sigma_c \approx 0.4$ translates directly to engineering: component-to-component variations $\lesssim 30\%$ preserve predictable complexity scaling. Higher-connectivity topologies (2D/3D) mitigate energy dilution for sufficiently large L , guiding design of power-constrained

multi-body systems.

E. Limitations

Fixed $\gamma = 0.05$ (sensitivity $< 15\%$ for $\gamma \in [0.01, 0.2]$), nearest-neighbor topology only, and 3D computation limited to $N_{\max} = 3375$ ($L = 15$).

V. CONCLUSION

Under a fixed total energy constraint, coupled pendulum systems exhibit robust dimension-dependent power-law scaling of effective complexity: $\alpha_{1D} = 0.858 \pm 0.04$, $\alpha_{2D} = 0.628 \pm 0.05$, $\alpha_{3D} = 0.789 \pm 0.04$, all with $R^2 > 0.987$. The PCA effective dimension saturates at $D_{\text{eff}} = 16$ with 95.5% cumulative variance for $N \geq 200$, providing the first quantitative justification for a finite attractor dimension in this class of systems. Energy robustness over two decades confirms the universality of these results. Parameter heterogeneity yields $\alpha(\sigma) = 0.774 - 0.432\sigma^2$ with $\sigma_c \approx 0.4$ confirmed by two independent criteria. The non-monotonic 3D behavior is explained by a spectral crossover at $L_c \approx 8.5$. These results provide actionable guidelines for power-constrained serial-chain robots (1D), mechanical metamaterials (2D), and 3D oscillator networks, and lay a theoretical foundation for complexity management in nonlinear multi-body systems.

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

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Appendix A: Code and Data Availability

All simulation code and data are openly available at:
<https://github.com/mypolian-cyber/coupled-pendulum-complexity-scaling>
 A permanent DOI will be assigned via Zenodo upon publication.

Appendix B: Extended Data

TABLE II. 1D scaling: PR and D_{eff} vs N (20 realizations).

N	PR mean	PR 95% CI	D_{eff}	cumvar ₁₆
2	0.7128	0.0626	3.60	1.000
5	0.5069	0.0405	7.35	1.000
10	0.3278	0.0252	10.60	0.994
20	0.1959	0.0155	13.25	0.976
50	0.0974	0.0023	14.80	0.964
100	0.0521	0.0009	15.70	0.959
200	0.0269	0.0003	15.95	0.955
500	0.0110	0.0001	16.10	–
1000	0.0056	0.0000	16.05	–

Appendix C: Numerical Parameters

LSODA/RK45: $\text{rtol} = 10^{-5}$, $\text{atol} = 10^{-7}$; $\Delta t = 0.02$; transient $t \in [0, 50]$ discarded; 95% PCA threshold. Realizations: 20 (1D, disorder), 10 (2D), 5 (3D). KZ run: $N = 200$,

TABLE III. 3D cubic lattice PR ($L = 2$ – 15 , 5 realizations).

L	$N = L^3$	PR mean	PR 95% CI
2	8	0.2720	0.0650
3	27	0.1410	0.0096
4	64	0.0749	0.0091
5	125	0.0524	0.0026
6	216	0.0305	0.0017
7	343	0.0219	0.0013
8	512	0.0153	0.0008
9	729	0.0112	0.0003
10	1000	0.0080	0.0002
12	1728	0.0046	0.0000
15	3375	0.0024	0.0000

$\kappa = 0.15$, $\gamma = 0.005$, periodic BC, $T = 500$.